disarm them. He was determined to talk to the sceptical dealers and clear their apprehensions. He knew that most of them were unhappy that the ownership of the legendary brands had shifted to what they viewed as a third-world nation.

Having spent nearly a decade in the US in his youth, Ratan was aware, as he said many years later in 2015, that the country had ‘always been the bellwether of the global auto industry’. It was also a large market for both Jaguar and Land Rover as their sales in North America, from 2008–09 to 2012–13, would testify. Together, in this region, the two brands sold 85.8 per cent of the vehicles they sold in the UK. Further, the growth in the US market alone during this period, was 88.32 per cent, which was more than 10 per cent of the growth in the UK during the same period. This made it more important for Ratan to clear the air about any apprehensions they may have harboured about the Tatas’ intentions or capabilities.

The first trip he took was in March–April 2008. It was a six-day, eight-town tour. The dealers who had been miffed by Ford’s indifference in engaging with them were pleasantly surprised with Ratan’s unorthodox and endearing style. The first dealer he met was Gorin, his worst critic.

After the intimidating and tough-talking Gorin met Ratan, he became the chairman’s most ardent admirer. He comments that Ratan came across as a ‘humble, genuine and inclusive’ person. He was responsive and took immediate steps to sort out things according to customer feedback, Gorin adds.

Gorin was especially swayed by Ratan’s soft approach. He says, ‘Being the brilliant man Ratan is’, he engaged him for nearly seven hours. He now says, ‘We were like long-lost friends … At the end of the meeting, he called me his kindred spirit … I could not get a more humbling comment. What an elegant man, what a humble man, [a] brilliant man …’

He did not just air this view privately. Speaking to *Autoweek*, he admitted, ‘I was wrong. Any concern I may have had been completely dispelled. I couldn’t be more impressed. Ratan Tata is very humble and self-effacing.’ He went on to add, ‘He’s also a fully engaged entrepreneur, and Jaguar hasn’t been run by an entrepreneur since the beginning of time.’

‘The negativity went away rather quickly because of Ratan Tata himself,’ as he went around meeting dealers, listening to their concerns and telling them about his plans, says Jordan Aron, son of Allen Aron and the principal dealer of JLR in Illinois. The senior Aron adds that many had not even